

Case Study 16

Baby Albert

Building on the research of Pavlov and his principles of conditioned reflexes, John Watson, an American Psychologist, and his research assistant, Rosalie Rayner, conducted an experiment whereby a fear response was conditioned in an otherwise healthy and fearless baby boy. What Watson and Rayner wanted to prove was that behaviour is the result of learning and that learning is a classically conditioned response to environmental stimulus.

In 1920, Watson and Rayner performed their now infamous experiment on a healthy baby boy named Albert. Upon evaluation, they found Albert to be unusually calm and well-behaved. Nothing seemed to disturb or frighten the baby, not even fire. The infant was confronted suddenly and in rapid succession with a white rat, a rabbit, a dog, and a monkey and with masks with and without hair, cotton wool, and burning newspapers. Although Albert had not been exposed to any of these stimuli before, at no time did Albert display fear or apprehension. To determine whether a fear reaction could be elicited in Albert, an extremely loud sound was made by striking a hammer on a steel bar behind Albert's head. Indeed, Albert did not like this sound – he startled and his lips began to pucker and tremble. On the third striking of the bar, Albert began crying. This was the first time a situation in the laboratory had produced any fear or crying in Albert. At this time Albert was 9 months old.

Two months after their initial encounter with Albert, Watson and Rayner attempted to condition Albert to fear a white rat. Rayner supervised the baby while Albert interacted with the rat. Watson stood behind Albert and every time Albert reached for the rat, Watson smacked the bar with the hammer. Just as predicted, the noise scared Albert.



Watson and Rayner, over several days, paired the white rat with the loud noise. As predicted, Albert eventually exhibited fear at the presence of the rat alone. This reaction was similar to Pavlov's dog's salivation at the sound of a bell in the absence of food. Watson and Rayner had successfully conditioned, in Albert, fear at the sight of a white rat. **Generalization** had also occurred with Albert as his fear was not confined to only white rats. Albert became fearful of other furry animals, Watson's hair, sealskin coats -- even Santa Claus beards.

Unfortunately for Albert, the conditioning was not reversed because Albert was adopted soon after the conditioning occurred and Watson and Rayner were unable to locate him.